

We aim to look and feel local by sharing information in the local language, using the local currency, and using formats that resonate with the region.

Could you outline DigiKey's year-one priorities for India: what is a key challenge, and what role will partners play in giving even the smallest Indian customers full-catalogue access?

Our primary focus is serving the end market. India presents a strong opportunity, though some bureaucracy remains, particularly in import processes.

Our model centres on shipping all products from a single location, which allows us to offer the world's largest selection. This works because we aggregate demand across India, China, Germany, and other countries, making it financially viable to hold such a broad inventory. If we relied on local or regional warehouses, we would only be able to offer a partial range, as manufacturers' minimum order quantities make it impractical to stock small fractions of the catalogue in every region.

In the first year, our priority is to ensure a smooth, transparent import process for Indian customers. By working with partners such as Aqtronics, we want even the smallest companies and individual engineers to access our full catalogue with ease.

With these improvements, should customers expect faster delivery timelines?

Speed depends heavily on our carriers. We are fortunate that major logistics providers such as DHL, FedEx, and UPS operate directly from our facility. Shipments are pre-sorted as they come off the line, whether they are travelling within the US or heading overnight to India.

These carriers are actively working to shorten delivery cycles to Europe and Asia. A major focus is on reducing customs clearance time. As we build greater credibility with Indian customs authorities, we

expect to save several hours and, in some cases, a full day. Customers often tell us that our biggest advantage is converting supplier lead times of weeks or months into just a few days of transit.

Considering your visibility into both purchasing behaviour and website traffic, what major shifts have you observed in how engineers, OEMs, and design teams source components today?

Traditionally, companies forecast demand based on past purchasing patterns. However, technology now moves too quickly for that approach alone. We also monitor early design signals. We gather similar insights from suppliers by tracking which components customers explore on their platforms. These signals help us stay aligned with engineers' interests.

Are you also working on FAE enablement or smart recommendations for existing users, leveraging LLMs or GenAI?

Each component represents an engineer's complete design effort, so our platform must support the entire journey. Increasingly, engineers use DigiKey for research, including accessing datasheets, reference designs, development boards, and EDA symbols. As search becomes more complex, we are improving parameter visibility, comparison tools, and filtering capabilities to make discovery easier.

Many engineers rely on small local distributors but worry about counterfeit parts. How is the industry addressing this issue?

Counterfeiting is probably the issue that keeps everyone awake at night. We are part of an industry association whose core mission is to support authorised distribution. At DigiKey, this is straightforward: we never purchase excess or grey-market inventory, even when it appears legitimate. Every product we stock comes directly from the manufacturer. When engineers buy from

DigiKey, they can be confident that the component is genuine.

From an academic perspective, how important is supporting student and university programmes, and are there any plans or programmes specifically in the pipeline for India?

Customer relationships often begin early, which is why we support programmes such as FIRST Robotics. We are strong advocates of STEM and of putting technology directly into students' hands.

We have dedicated teams focused on the academic environment. These teams will continue expanding internationally, including in India, by partnering with universities and schools focused on engineering education.

With India's semiconductor ecosystem growing, what role do you see DigiKey playing in supporting design teams and helping smaller manufacturers reach global markets?

Advanced semiconductors are complex, so we collaborate with suppliers and third parties to provide development environments and tools that help engineers understand and apply these technologies. When accelerometers first emerged, they became practical only after engineers could test them in real-world environments. We aim to provide that same level of support for every advanced device.

Are there any success stories of companies that partnered with DigiKey and gained international exposure or scaled with your support?

SparkFun and Adafruit are strong examples from the United States. Both started as DigiKey customers and later became important suppliers. Their mission is to simplify technology for new engineers, which closely aligns with ours. **EFY**

This interview is an excerpt of a longer discussion. For the full transcript, please visit: <https://efy.co.in/interviewjan26>

